

SKILL DRILL

Directions (Q.1-Q.25): Read the passage given below and answer the question that follows

1. Local authorities are considering an amendment to the litter law that would raise the fine for littering in the community picnic area to \$1,000. Since the inception of the litter law, **incremental increases in the littering fine have proven to be consistently effective at further reducing the amount of litter in the community picnic area.** However, raising the fine to \$1,000 would actually have the unintended effect of increasing the amount of litter in the picnic area. **Picnic area users would perceive this fine to be unreasonable and unenforceable, and would disregard the litter law altogether.**

In the argument, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is irrefutable evidence that the author offers in support of a prediction; the second is that prediction.
 (b) The first is a statement of causation that the author predicts will be repeated in the case at hand; the second raises evidence against this prediction.
 (c) The first is a statement of fact that the author accepts to be true; the second is presented as a consequence of this fact.
 (d) The first is a statement of causation that the author predicts will not hold in the case at hand; the second offers a line of reasoning to support this prediction.

2. Political analyst: A party that temporarily positions itself in the negligible crack between the American right and left will do little to expand the public debate. What America needs is a permanent third party. **Some claim that America's success stems from the two party system.** These people say that a third party would make the passage of legislation and thus governance impossible. Furthermore, they point to the current sluggish pace of government as proof that the country cannot bear the burden of a third party. **Yet, most European countries have multi-party systems and few complain about any inability to govern there.**

Which of the following best describes the functions of the two sections in boldface in the argument above?

- (a) The first is the main point of the argument; the second is a premise that supports that point.
 (b) The first opposes the premises of the argument; the second is the claim that the argument supports.

- (c) The first supports the main position held by opponents of the main point; the second is a premise that argues against that position.

- (d) The first is the primary claim made by opponents of the main point of the argument; the second is evidence proposed in opposition to the first.

3. Letter to the editor: Proposition Q, a controversial measure on this year's ballot, would prohibit the ownership of handguns within the city's limits. Under the plan, gun owners would have a 90-day grace period to turn in their weapons to authorities. Proponents of the proposition argue that **fewer handguns on the streets would lead to less violent crime, making the city safer for all of its citizens.** Unfortunately, the ban would actually have the opposite effect. Since only law abiding citizens would honor the ban, **armed criminals would not only keep their weapons but would also have the confidence to act with impunity on a population that could no longer defend itself.**

In the letter to the editor, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is an observation that the author uses to support a particular position; the second is that position.
 (b) The first is a pattern of cause and effect that the author believes to be true; the second offers evidence to contradict this pattern.
 (c) The first is a position that the author argues will not hold in this case; the second is the author's position.
 (d) The first is a direct relationship that the author believes will not hold in this case; the second offers evidence in support of the author's position.

4. Scientist: Evolutionary biology has long held that the most attractive males of a species, defined as those with the highest quality physical traits that have no Darwinian survival value, will draw the most female mates. **The resulting male offspring will inherit that attractiveness and themselves have more children as a result,** thus ensuring widespread dissemination of the grandparents' genes. Recently, however, scientists have found that the sons of "high quality" male flycatchers failed to inherit the father's mating status. Further, the most attractive males were so busy mating that they neglected their offspring; **as a result, the sons of homelier birds, who took better care of their offspring, had more success at propagating**



the species.

The two portions in boldface play which of the following roles in the scientist's argument?

- (a) The first is the conclusion of a theory disputed by the scientist; the second is the scientist's new contention based upon the latest evidence.
- (b) The first is a premise of a long-held biological theory; the second is an example of how this theory works.
- (c) The first is an explanation of how a biological theory is thought to work; the second is an example of research results that do not support this theory.
- (d) The first is an example of a theory that used to be prevalent; the second is the new theory that is now considered predominant by scientists.

5. Traditionally, video game manufacturers have been most strongly influenced by serious video gamers. Because devoted gamers have historically purchased the majority of video games, companies react to the desires of this market segment. Normally, devoted gamers crave speed and action; **thus, most manufacturers continue to produce games with faster chips and flashier graphics.** Unfortunately, faster chips and flashier graphics are no longer in the industry's best interest. **The devoted gaming market is deeply stagnant, and it won't soon expand.** To infuse new life into the video game market, manufacturers must simplify the functionality of their games. By doing so, current non-gamers will be attracted to join the ranks of video game fans.

In the argument, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is a situation that the author believes to be true; the second offers evidence to explain this situation.
- (b) The first is a situation that the author argues should not continue; the second provides evidence that supports the author's position.
- (c) The first is a statement of fact that contradicts the author's position; the second is the author's position.
- (d) The first is a statement of fact that supports the author's position; the second is a consideration that weighs against the author's position.

6. Musical composers have generally made their most significant contributions to the musical canon before they reached the age of thirty. It is commonly believed that this is the case because **aging brings about a loss of cognitive ability and creative capacity.** However, a study pointed out that **a disproportionately large number of those composers who made their most significant contributions to the canon after the age of thirty became musicians at an older age than is**

generally the case. Since by the age of thirty many composers have been engaged as musicians for a decade or more, these findings suggest that the real reason why musicians over thirty rarely make significant contributions to the musical canon is not that they have aged but rather that they have spent too much time as musicians.

In the argument above, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is an explanation that is challenged by the argument; the second is a finding used to support that explanation.
- (b) The first is an explanation that the argument opposes; the second is an objection raised against the alternative explanation advocated by the argument.
- (c) The first is a claim advanced in support of a position; the second is a finding that clarifies that position.
- (d) The first is an explanation that the argument challenges; the second is a finding on which that challenge is based.

7. The city government should invest surplus funds in improving the city's transportation network. **Most of the network was put in place at a time when the city was much smaller in both area and population.** The subway system is outdated and understaffed. The buses rarely run on schedule and their routes are inconvenient. **If the city does not make changes soon to the network, it will see many of its prized industries relocate to more convenient cities and, as a result, the city's financial health will be jeopardized.**

In the argument above, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is an explanation of a current state of affairs; the second is a prediction based on that state of affairs.
- (b) The first is a statement of fact in opposition to the author's conclusion; the second is that conclusion.
- (c) The first emphasizes an existing problem; the second offers a proposal to solve that problem.
- (d) The first is information the author suggests has been overlooked in the situation at hand; the second describes that situation.

8. Chief Economist: Usually, **the release of economic data about higher-than-expected growth in the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) results in an increase in stock prices.** However, this quarter, the release of data about strong GDP growth is most likely to result in a decrease rather than an increase in stock prices. **Robust GDP growth will lead to higher interest rates, increasing the attractiveness of bonds and causing a shift of capital from equity to**



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debt securities.

In the above argument, the statements in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first acknowledges a consideration against the main conclusion of the chief economist; the second is that conclusion.
 - (b) The first is a pattern of cause and effect that the chief economist predicts will not hold in the case at issue; the second offers a consideration in support of that prediction.
 - (c) The first is a generalization that the chief economist accepts as true; the second is a consequence that follows from that generalization.
 - (d) The first is evidence that the chief economist provides in support of a certain prediction; the second is that prediction.
9. Political Analyst: After the Soviet Union collapsed, some hoped that freedom would encourage Russians to multiply, but as a result of dislocation and insecurity, the Russian population continues to dwindle at the rate of 700,000 a year. The government proposes to address the problem with a wide range of financial incentives, along with investments in improved health care, road safety and the like. These are positive measures, **but they have been tried before, to little avail.** A better plan to reverse the population decline is to improve the country's governance in both the public and the private sphere. **If a greater part of the population participated in important decisions and shared in the country's wealth, then larger families would result.** In addition, if corruption and greed among the elite were curbed, public health would improve and average life expectancy would increase.
- The two boldfaced statements serve what function in the argument above?
- (a) The first is the main point of the analyst's argument; the second is a premise that supports the first.
 - (b) The first is a premise that undermines an alternative to the analyst's proposal; the second is a premise that supports the analyst's main claim.
 - (c) The first is a premise that contradicts the main point made by the analyst; the second is the main point of the argument.
 - (d) The first is a premise that supports a proposal; the second is that proposal.
10. United Energy recently invested in a series of large windmills which are able to produce renewable energy with minimal negative effect to the environment. The company has not drilled oil wells in the same area, even though **greater revenues and**

profits could be generated from oil wells. Because any drilling would disrupt the native habitat of certain marine species in the area, some environmentalists assert that, by foregoing this drilling, **United Energy has established that it places environmental impact over financial returns.** However, United Energy may be acting in a manner consistent with its financial goals. Recent patterns of increasing annual hurricane activity have some experts questioning the long-term viability and profitability of oil wells in the area.

The two boldfaced portions play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first supports the conclusion of the argument; the second calls that conclusion into question.
 - (b) The first states the conclusion of the argument; the second supports that conclusion.
 - (c) The first supports the environmentalists' conclusion; the second states that conclusion.
 - (d) The first states the environmentalists' conclusion; the second provides a consideration in support of that conclusion.
11. Marketing Analyst: Traditionally, **introducing a new consumer product contributes to the diversity of a company's product mix and results in an overall increase in revenues and profits.** However, our launch of a new brand of soft drinks, Cool Breeze, planned for the end of this fiscal year, will almost certainly reduce rather than increase the company's profits. Since we already offer a line of chilled refreshments that are very similar to Cool Breeze, the launch of the new drink is likely to cannibalize our current sales rather than attract new customers. Additionally, **since the costs of producing Cool Breeze are higher than those of the other chilled refreshments, a large part of our current sales will be replaced with lower-margin revenues.**
- In the argument above, which of the following statements best describes the role played by each portion in boldface?
- (a) The first is a pattern of cause and effect that the marketing analyst predicts will be repeated in the case at issue; the second acknowledges a circumstance in which that pattern would not hold.
 - (b) The first is a generalization that the marketing analyst accepts as true; the second is a consequence that follows from that generalization.
 - (c) The first acknowledges a consideration against the main conclusion of the marketing analyst; the second is that conclusion.
 - (d) The first is a pattern of cause and effect that the marketing analyst predicts will not hold in the case at



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issue; the second offers a consideration in support of that prediction.

12. **Letter writer:** Illegal drug use is often associated with other serious problems, such as armed robbery and other violent crimes. Statistics indicate that **each time police increase their enforcement of anti-drug laws in the city, the number of violent crimes committed in the city declines as a result.** However, eliminating criminal penalties for drug use would almost certainly decrease rather than increase the incidence of armed robbery and other violent crime. **If drugs were no longer illegal, the price would drop precipitously, and drug users would no longer need to commit crimes to acquire the money necessary to support their drug habits.**

In the letter writer's argument, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is support offered by the letter writer for a certain forecast; the second is that forecast.
- (b) The first acknowledges an observation that refutes the main position that the letter writer takes; the second is that position.
- (c) The first is a direct relationship between two activities that the letter writer argues is an infallible predictor of future events; the second acknowledges a circumstance in which that relationship would not apply.
- (d) The first is a direct relationship between two activities that the letter writer predicts will not hold in the future; the second offers information that, if true, would support that prediction.

13. **Real Estate Agent:** Next year, the occupancy rate for residential rental properties in Riverton will increase despite projections of decreasing population in the city. Generally, when a city's population decreases, so does the occupancy rate for residential rental properties. However, **in the continuing climate of increasing interest rates on home mortgages, an unusually large number of Riverton residents who would typically buy homes will opt to rent instead.**

The boldfaced statements in the argument above play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is a conclusion drawn by the agent; the second is evidence that weighs against the agent's conclusion.
- (b) The first is a consideration that weighs against the agent's prediction; the second is that prediction.
- (c) The first describes a pattern of cause and effect; the second describes a situation for which this pattern will not hold.

- (d) The first is the agent's prediction; the second is reasoning offered in support of this prediction.

14. **Policy analyst:** Most government agencies become less effective over time. Some experts go so far as to recommend that every agency be eliminated after 10 years and created anew by replacing all of its existing personnel and revamping its bureaucratic structure. However, this policy would be impractical since **certain government agencies perform vital functions, such as protecting national security, and therefore cannot afford even temporary upheaval.**

In the policy analyst's argument above, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is evidence offered in support of an opinion that the policy analyst rejects; the second offers information that contradicts that evidence.
- (b) The first is a premise that the policy analyst accepts but argues against; the second offers evidence that supports the analyst's position.
- (c) The first is a position that the policy analyst argues against; the second is the position that the analyst defends.
- (d) The first is a generalization that the policy analyst accepts as accurate and is used as the basis for an opinion that the analyst rejects; the second is a consideration used to defend the analyst's position.

15. **Political Candidate:** Government subsidized prescription drug plans that would allow individuals significant choice in determining their benefits and costs are deceptively appealing to numerous stakeholders. However, buying prescription drug coverage, like buying health insurance coverage, is not like buying a car. **The consumer cannot predict his or her future health needs.** Moreover, the administrators of the choice-based drug plans under consideration are allowed to change the drugs they cover and the prices they charge at any time; this renders informed consumer choice meaningless and makes securing appropriate coverage a crap shoot. Older and disabled individuals, the predominant consumers of government subsidized prescription drug plans, should be offered drug coverage alternatives that do not force them to gamble with their health.

In the argument above, the two portions in boldface play which of the following roles?

- (a) The first is a fact that the candidate argues against; the second is the ultimate claim that the candidate supports.



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- (b) The first is an observation which the candidate acknowledges as true but to which he is ultimately opposed; the second is a claim that the candidate uses as evidence to support his ultimate position.
- (c) The first is an observation that the candidate acknowledges as true but unfortunate; the second is an assertion that the candidate makes to support his ultimate position.
- (d) The first is an observation that the candidate argues against; the second is an observation that the candidate supports.

16. When the 16-year old Chinese Ye Shiwen broke the women's 400-m individual medley world record during London Olympics 2012, many magazines and newspapers from the USA and UK accused her of doping and foul play. A prestigious science journal also handpicked data to discredit her, thus ignoring large amount of vital data that was in her favor. Thus, such cherry picking of data and reports prove that western media is heavily biased against the Chinese.

The author's reasoning is vulnerable to criticism on the grounds that:

- (a) It portrays the views of the prestigious science journal as more extreme than they really are.
- (b) The author mistakes effect for a cause.
- (c) The claims made by the author contradict his evidence.
- (d) He himself uses the tactics he is accusing the western media of.

17. Researcher: It is commonly believed that species belonging to the same biological order, such as rodents, descended from a single common ancestor. However, I compared the genetic pattern in 3 rodent species — guinea pigs, rats, and mice—as well as in 13 non-rodent mammals, and found that while rats and mice are genetically quite similar, the genetic differences between guinea pigs and mice are as great as those between mice and some non-rodent species. Thus, despite their similar physical form, guinea pigs stem from a separate ancestor.

Which one of the following, if true, most seriously undermines the researcher's reasoning?

- (a) The researcher examined the genetic material of only 3 of over 2,000 species of rodents.
- (b) Some pairs of species not having a common ancestor are genetically more similar to each other than are some pairs that do have a common ancestor.
- (c) The researcher selected non-rodent species that have the specific cell structures she wanted to analyze genetically, though many non-rodent mammals lack these cell structures.

- (d) For some genuine biological orders, the most recent common ancestor dates from later epochs than does the most recent common ancestor of other biological orders.

18. Landscape architect: If the screen between these two areas is to be a hedge, that hedge must be of either hemlocks or Leyland cypress trees. However, Leyland cypress trees cannot be grown this far north. So if the screen is to be a hedge, it will be a hemlock hedge.

In which one of the following is the pattern of reasoning most similar to that in the landscape architect's argument?

- (a) If there is to be an entrance on the north side of the building, it will have to be approached by a ramp. However, a ramp would become impossibly slippery in winter, so there will be no entrance on the north side.
- (b) If visitors are to travel to this part of the site by automobile, there will be a need for parking spaces. However, no parking spaces are allowed for in the design. So if visitors are likely to come by automobile, the design will be changed.
- (c) The subsoil in these five acres either consists entirely of clay or consists entirely of shale. Therefore, if one test hole in the area reveals shale, it will be clear that the entire five acres has a shale subsoil.
- (d) Any path along this embankment must be either concrete or stone. But a concrete path cannot be built in this location. So if there is to be a path on the embankment, it will be a stone path.

19. The university's purchasing department is highly efficient overall. We must conclude that each of its twelve staff members is highly efficient.

Which one of the following arguments exhibits flawed reasoning most similar to that exhibited by the argument above?

- (a) The employees at this fast-food restaurant are the youngest and most inexperienced of any fast-food workers in the city. Given this, it seems obvious that customers will have to wait longer for their food at this restaurant than at others.
- (b) The outside audit of our public relations department has exposed serious deficiencies in the competence of each member of that department. We must conclude that the department is inadequate for our needs.
- (c) This supercomputer is the most sophisticated—and the most expensive—ever built. It must be that each of its components is the most sophisticated and expensive available.



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- (d) Literature critics have lavished praise on every chapter of this book. In light of their reviews, one must conclude that the book is excellent.

20. While there are certain dog-training techniques that generally tend to be effective for most dogs, it is important to keep in mind that each dog will respond particularly well to certain techniques that other dogs might not be receptive to. Therefore, the best practice is to keep general principles in mind when training dogs, while tailoring their educations to their particular traits.

Which of the following propositions does this reasoning above most closely conform to?

- (a) While a general set of principles exist for accomplishing a goal, it is important to acknowledge the unique circumstances or qualities that may exist, and to take them into consideration.
- (b) Even though general principles are broad enough to encompass most individuals or circumstances, there will always be outliers that require special attention.
- (c) It is dangerous to apply a broad set of principles to a set of unique individuals because they will react to the same set of circumstances differently.
- (d) Unique individuals and unique circumstances call for specialized training to meet their needs.

21. If a wine receives a high score from the National Sommelier Association, it is more likely to be sold in fine-dining restaurants. A new wine from Oregon just received a high score from the National Sommelier Association. Therefore, it is more likely to be sold in fine-dining restaurants.

Which of the following choices most closely reflects the reasoning in the argument above?

- (a) Older coins are more valuable. Anita has a coin believed to have originated from the colonial era, but lacks any proof. Therefore, it is questionable whether her coin is valuable.
- (b) Pearls that are larger than average are more likely to retail for a higher price. A pearl diver found a dozen pearls that are much larger than average. Therefore, the pearls are more likely to retail for a higher price.
- (c) Famous actors tend to appear in popular movies. Popular movies often feature famous actors. Therefore, it is unlikely to find a popular movie without famous actors.
- (d) Brighter colors attract more attention. The professor attracts a lot of attention. Therefore, he probably tends to wear more bright colors.

22. All English Springer Spaniels have long hair. All Rottweilers have short hair. Each of Tina's dogs is a cross between an English Springer Spaniel and a Rottweiler. Therefore, Tina's dogs have medium-length hair.

Which one of the following uses flawed reasoning that most closely resembles the flawed reasoning used in the argument above?

- (a) All typists who practice at least one hour per day can type one hundred words per minute. But some typists who do not practice can also type one hundred words per minute. Mike, a typist, practices thirty minutes per day. Therefore, Mike types fifty words per minute.
- (b) All economists know linear algebra. All physicists know relativistic mechanics. Wilma is both an economist and a physicist. Therefore, Wilma knows both linear algebra and relativistic mechanics.
- (c) All halogen gases are toxic to humans. All non-radioactive noble gases are non-toxic to humans. "Nobagen" gas is a mixture of a halogen gas and a noble gas. Therefore, "nobagen" gas is moderately toxic to humans.
- (d) All players on the Wildcats have brown hair. All players on the Razorbacks have red hair. Members of the Moye family are on both the Wildcats and the Razorbacks. Therefore, some members of the Moye family have brown hair and others have red hair.

23. City resident: These new digital electronic billboards should be banned for light pollution since they are much too bright.

Outdoor advertising spokesperson: No, that's not true. Testing with a sophisticated light meter shows that at night they throw off less light than traditional billboards that are reflectively lit. Your mistaken perception that they are brighter comes from looking directly at the light source—the screen itself.

The underlying strategy of the spokesperson's response to the resident is most analogous to the underlying strategy of which of the following?

- (a) A doctor dismisses a patient's claim to have had a heart attack, citing a cardiac enzyme blood test.
- (b) A politician rejects an accusation of perjury by denying the credibility of witness testimony.
- (c) An insurance agent rejects a claim, on the grounds that there is insufficient evidence to support the claimant's testimony.
- (d) An investigator casts doubt on the results of a lie detector, citing the subject's report of illness during the test.
- (d) A psychologist treats a mental illness by encouraging a patient to abandon inconsistent beliefs.



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24. A high school football coach has made public comments criticizing the decision by the football coaching staff of the local university to not play their star quarterback. However, we should not listen to the high school coach's criticism. His high school football team has not won a game in several seasons.

The flawed reasoning above most closely resembles which of the following arguments?

- (a) We should not listen to the neurobiologist's predictions about the future state of the economy because he has no formal training in economics.
- (b) We should not listen to this art critic's negative comments because it is well known that the art critic is a mediocre artist.
- (c) We should not listen to the car salesperson because she has an incentive to ignore negative features of the car in order to make commission off of a sale.
- (d) It is likely that the scholar plagiarized this paper because she has been known to plagiarize in the past.

25. Poet: True sincerity is spoken from the heart, without filters. This form of expression contrasts sharply with what is (sadly) the more common way of speaking: a

manner in which communication is made to create a comfortable situation, rather than to speak the truth.
Which of the following individuals best embodies the message that the poet is conveying?

- (a) A writer, outraged that no publishing house has yet agreed to publish his manuscript, sends an angry email to his agent in order to release his frustrations. The writer's email accuses the agent of not advocating on his behalf with enough zeal.
- (b) A piano teacher, aggravated at his pupil's refusal to practice, vents to a colleague that the pupil's lack of motivation has caused him to feel utterly unmotivated as well.
- (c) A mother, worried that her son will not earn good grades if he does not start studying, tells him, "If you want to get into college, you really need to start doing your homework."
- (d) While a husband is out with his wife, he wants her to feel loved and appreciated. He tells her in complete honesty that from the moment he saw her, he thought she was stunning and had felt immediately drawn to her.



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